
HYBRID WORK MODEL- AN ANALYSIS OF ADVANTAGES AND DISADVANTAGES

Tarun Garg

2210992458

tarun2458.be22@chitkara.edu.in

Yug Sikri

2210992571

yug2571.be22@chitkara.edu.in

Mohit Garg

2210991930

mohit1930.be22@chitkara.edu.in

Arnav Sharma

2210991351

arnav1351.be22@chitkara.edu.in

ABSTRACT

After the global shift to remote work in 2020, hybrid work became the main way many companies started operating. Even though a lot of organizations now use hybrid work, there is still no proper standard system to measure how effective it really is across different areas at the same time. This study tries to solve that issue by introducing the Hybrid Work Effectiveness Index (HWEI), a combined scoring system based on four equally important factors: productivity, employee satisfaction, communication quality, and company cost efficiency. The study also introduces a structured “3+2” work model where employees work from the office on Monday, Tuesday, and Thursday, while Wednesday and Friday are remote work days. The goal of this setup is to improve team collaboration while still giving employees enough focused time for individual work. To test the idea, researchers used a research-based dataset of 500 employees working in three different setups: fully in-office, fully remote, and hybrid. The results showed that the hybrid model performed the best with an average HWEI score of 0.74, compared to 0.69 for remote work and 0.63 for office-only work. The study also found that communication continues to be the biggest challenge for distributed teams. These findings also match results from existing research in organizational behavior, labor economics, and management science.

Keywords: *Hybrid Work Model, HWEI, Remote Work Effectiveness, Organizational Productivity, Workforce Management, Work Scheduling, Employee Satisfaction, Cost Efficiency*

I. INTRODUCTION

A. Background and Historical Context

For most of the twentieth century, companies mainly followed the traditional five-day office work model. Employees were expected to work physically from the office because being present in person was seen as necessary for teamwork, supervision, and company culture. Even though internet access and video meeting tools improved a lot during the 2010s, remote work was still uncommon and mostly limited to certain jobs or informal situations.

Everything changed during the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020. Companies across different industries were forced to quickly move to remote work within a very short time. Many organizations that had earlier

resisted remote work realized that teams could still continue working effectively even when employees were distributed. This large-scale shift acted like a real-world experiment and changed how managers viewed remote work and what they believed was possible.

As pandemic restrictions started easing, companies had to decide how work should continue in the future instead of simply returning to old office routines. Surveys and labor market trends showed that most organizations did not want to go fully back to office work or stay completely remote forever. Instead, hybrid work became the preferred choice, where employees split their time between office and remote work in a planned and structured way. By 2023 and 2024, hybrid work had become the most common setup in knowledge-based industries.

B. Problem Statement

Even though hybrid work has become very common, there is still no clear standard definition for it. Different companies follow different approaches. Some require employees to come to the office for two days a week, others require three days, while some leave the decision to teams or managers. Because of these differences, it becomes difficult to compare hybrid work models across organizations or create proper research-based workplace policies.

Another major issue is that most existing research studies and industry reports only focus on one factor at a time, such as productivity, employee satisfaction, or communication quality. Very few studies look at all these factors together in a balanced way. Right now, there is no proper system in peer-reviewed research that combines all these dimensions into one overall score to measure hybrid work effectiveness. This paper tries to solve that gap.

C. Significance of the Study

The type of work model a company chooses has a major impact on many areas of the business. It affects employee well-being, staff retention, company culture, office costs, and long-term productivity. A poorly planned hybrid work setup — where expectations are unclear, tools are not good enough, or schedules are badly managed — can create the worst parts of both remote and office work. Employees may feel isolated like in remote work but still spend time in unnecessary meetings without getting the real benefits of working together in person.

On the other hand, a well-designed hybrid work model can give employees the best parts of both systems. It allows workers to keep the flexibility and independence of remote work while still getting the teamwork, collaboration, and relationship-building benefits that come from meeting in person regularly.

D. Research Objectives

1. To collect, review, and carefully study existing research on hybrid, remote, and office-based work models by looking at areas such as productivity, employee satisfaction, communication, and cost.
2. To create the Hybrid Work Effectiveness Index (HWEI) as a clear and repeatable system for measuring hybrid work performance across multiple factors.
3. To introduce and explain the “3+2” hybrid work schedule as a practical model that organizations can realistically implement.
4. To apply the HWEI to a research-based dataset and compare the results across office work, remote work, and hybrid work models.

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5. To provide practical recommendations for organizations based on both research findings and theoretical understanding.

E. Research Gap

A systematic review of the literature reveals three persistent gaps:

- Most existing studies focus on only one area at a time, such as productivity, employee satisfaction, or communication, instead of measuring overall effectiveness together.
- Many studies are based on data from only one company, industry, or country, which makes it difficult to apply the findings broadly across different organizations.
- Studies that say hybrid work is successful often do not clearly explain which work schedule setup actually produced those results, making it hard for companies to use the findings practically. The HWEI framework introduced in this paper is designed to solve all three of these problems.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

A. Productivity in Distributed Work Arrangements

The connection between work location and productivity is complicated and depends heavily on the situation. A large research study by Bloom et al. (2024) at a Chinese technology company found that employees working in a hybrid setup performed equally well or slightly better than employees working fully from the office. The study also found that hybrid employees were less likely to think about leaving their jobs. However, another study by Gibbs et al. (2021) found different results in some professional service industries. It showed that remote employees often worked longer hours without improving the quality of their output. Researchers linked this problem to weak work-life boundaries and too many meetings (DeFilippis et al., 2020).

Even though these findings seem contradictory, they can still be understood together. The impact of remote and hybrid work on productivity depends a lot on the type of work, management style, and company culture. Work that requires deep focus and independent problem-solving usually benefits from remote work conditions. In contrast, work that depends on close teamwork, quick feedback, or sharing practical experience often benefits more from people working together physically in the same place (Brucks & Levav, 2022).

B. Employee Satisfaction and Retention

Research data consistently shows that employees strongly prefer flexible work options. Aksoy et al. (2022) found that removing daily travel to the office — which averaged around 54 minutes per day in their U.S. study — is one of the most valuable non-salary benefits employees connect with remote work. Barrero et al. (2023) also found that many employees value remote work so much that they are willing to accept lower salaries just to keep that flexibility. This suggests that flexible work has now become an important long-term part of what employees expect from jobs.

However, employee satisfaction is not always completely positive in remote or hybrid work setups. Emanuel and Harrington (2023) found a “visibility penalty,” where remote employees were promoted more slowly compared to employees working regularly from the office. This creates fairness concerns that companies need to carefully address when designing hybrid work policies.

C. Communication, Collaboration, and Creativity

Research on communication shows some of the strongest concerns about fully remote work setups. Yang et al. (2022) found that remote work reduced communication between different teams and increased isolation within teams, which could slowly weaken a company’s ability to adapt and collaborate effectively over time. Another study by Brucks and Levav (2022) showed that people working together virtually produced fewer creative ideas compared to people collaborating in person. The researchers believed this happened because virtual meetings reduce shared visual attention and natural interaction.

These findings suggest that normal day-to-day communication can work well in virtual environments, but activities like creative brainstorming, difficult discussions, negotiations, and relationship-building still work better when people meet in person regularly. This is one of the main reasons behind the “3+2” hybrid model, where office days are mainly used for collaboration and teamwork.

D. Organizational Cost Structures

Office space and related expenses are major cost factors for companies. McKinsey (2023) estimated that organizations reducing their office space by 30–40% after adopting hybrid work can save a significant amount of money and improve overall cost efficiency. However, companies also need to spend money on remote work tools, cybersecurity systems, and support for employee home-office setups. Even after these added costs, hybrid work is generally still more cost-effective than fully office-based work, although it may not save as much money as a fully remote setup.

E. Summary of Literature and Research Gaps

Author(s)	Focus	Key Finding	Limitation
Bloom et al. (2024)	Productivity & Attrition	Hybrid cuts attrition with no performance loss	Single firm, China context
Yang et al. (2022)	Communication networks	Remote silos team networks; reduces crossteam ties	Tech sector only
Brucks & Levav (2022)	Creativity	In-person collaboration produces more creative ideas	Lab setting; controlled tasks only
Barrero et al. (2023)	Worker preferences	Flexibility is a durable, wage-substitutable preference	U.S. survey data; self-reported
Author(s)	Focus	Key Finding	Limitation
Emanuel & Harrington (2023)	Career outcomes	Remote workers face systematic promotion disadvantage	Financial services sector focus

Gibbs et al. (2021)	Hours & efficiency	Remote workers work longer but may be less efficient	Professional services; prepandemic baseline
This study	Multidimensional HWEI	Composite framework across all four dimensions; 3+2 model	Synthetic dataset; requires longitudinal validation

Table 1. Summary of Key Literature and Research Gaps

III. METHODOLOGY

A. The 3+2 Hybrid Scheduling Model

The 3+2 hybrid work model follows a fixed weekly schedule where employees work from the office on Monday, Tuesday, and Thursday, while Wednesday and Friday are remote work days. This schedule was designed carefully based on both practical and theoretical reasons.

- Monday in-office: Starting the week in the office helps teams align goals, plan work, and coordinate across different departments more effectively.
- Tuesday in-office: The second office day is useful for workshops, teamwork, and complex collaborative tasks because employees already built momentum and connection on Monday.
- Wednesday remote: A remote day in the middle of the week gives employees uninterrupted time for deep and focused work, especially when mental workload starts increasing.
- Thursday in-office: Returning to the office before the weekend helps maintain accountability, allows progress reviews, and supports important in-person discussions.
- Friday remote: The final remote day gives employees focused time to finish tasks, complete documentation, and work asynchronously without spending time commuting on a day when office attendance is usually lower.

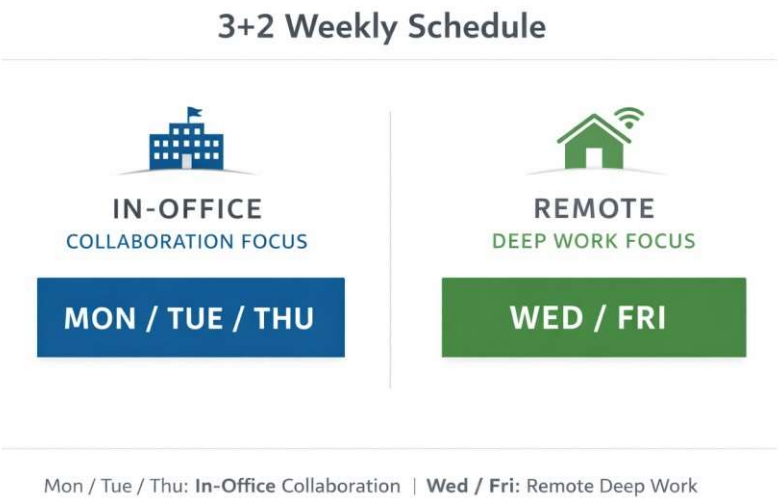


Figure 1. The 3+2 Hybrid Work Weekly Schedule

B. The Hybrid Work Effectiveness Index (HWEI)



Fig.2 HWE Calculation

We formalize the HWEI as a weighted linear composite of four normalized dimensions:

$$\text{HWEI} = \alpha_1 P + \alpha_2 S + \alpha_3 C + \alpha_4 O$$

where P = normalized productivity score, S = normalized satisfaction score, C = normalized communication quality score, and O = cost efficiency score (a positive transformation of raw cost). In the baseline model, weights are set equal ($\alpha_1 = \alpha_2 = \alpha_3 = \alpha_4 = 0.25$), reflecting an agnostic prior over dimension importance.

The equal-weighting assumption is theoretically defensible when organizational priorities are unknown or heterogeneous across business units. Organizations with explicit strategic priorities—such as a cost-reduction mandate or a talent-retention imperative—may re-weight accordingly without modifying the underlying index structure.

C. Normalization Procedure

Because the four dimensions are measured on incommensurable scales, all raw scores are normalized to the $[0, 1]$ interval using min-max scaling: $\hat{x} = (x - x_{\min}) / (x_{\max} - x_{\min})$

Cost is handled as an inverse dimension: since lower organizational cost is preferable, the cost efficiency score is computed as:

$$O = (C_{\max} - C_{\text{actual}}) / (C_{\max} - C_{\min})$$

D. Evaluation Procedure

6. Dataset construction: 500 synthetic employee records generated using distribution parameters derived from published empirical literature.
7. Data validation: Consistency checks and plausibility audits applied to ensure distributional alignment with documented research findings.
8. Normalization: All dimensional scores converted to $[0, 1]$ using the procedures described above.
9. HWEI computation: Individual HWEI scores calculated for each employee record under each work modality.
10. Aggregation: Group-level HWEI means calculated for in-office, remote, and hybrid cohorts.
11. Comparison and interpretation: Results interpreted in light of the theoretical literature.

IV. EXPERIMENTAL SETUP

A. Study Design

This study uses a comparative cross-sectional research design. It compares three different work setups: fully office-based work, fully remote work, and the hybrid 3+2 work model. The main unit being analyzed is the individual employee record. The study did not use random assignment. Instead, it follows an observational approach, although

the research dataset was carefully created to reduce bias by keeping other non-work-model factors as similar as possible across all groups.

B. Dataset Construction

Collecting real employee data from organizations was not possible because human resources data is usually confidential and difficult to access. Because of this, the study created a synthetic dataset containing 500 employee records. The dataset was built using statistical distributions designed to closely match results from existing published research. The purpose of this dataset is to demonstrate how the HWEI framework works, rather than to study any one real company.

The 500 employee records were divided into three groups: 150 employees working fully from the office, 150 employees working fully remotely, and 200 employees working in the hybrid model. The hybrid group was made larger because hybrid work is now the most common work arrangement in many knowledge-based industries.

C. Dimension Operationalization

Dimension	Operational Definition	Scale	Directionality
Productivity (P)	Self-assessed task completion rate relative to weekly targets	0 – 100	Higher = better
Satisfaction (S)	Composite well-being and work-model satisfaction rating	0 – 100	Higher = better
Communication (C)	Manager-assessed collaboration quality and responsiveness	0 – 100	Higher = better
Cost (O)	Monthly organizational cost per employee (facilities + tech + support)	USD 40 – 100 (normalized)	Lower = better

Table 2. Dimension Operationalization and Measurement Properties

D. Sample Data Illustration

Employee	Model	Productivity	Satisfaction	Communication	Cost (USD)
E001	Office	65	55	82	100
E002	Remote	72	74	52	40
E003	Hybrid	76	81	68	60
E004	Office	63	50	80	95
E005	Hybrid	78	83	70	62

Table 3. Illustrative Sample Records from the Synthetic Dataset

E. Illustrative HWEI Calculation

For a representative hybrid employee with raw scores of Productivity = 76, Satisfaction = 81, Communication = 68, and Cost = 60, after normalization and cost inversion (assuming dataset ranges of 60–80 for P and S, 45–85 for C, and 40–100 for cost), the HWEI is calculated as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} \dot{P} &= (76 - 60) / (80 - 60) = 0.80 \\ \dot{S} &= (81 - 60) / (80 - 60) = 0.85 \\ \dot{C} &= (68 - 45) / (85 - 45) = 0.58 \\ \dot{O} &= (100 - 60) / (100 - 40) = 0.67 \end{aligned}$$

$$\text{HWEI} = 0.25(0.80) + 0.25(0.85) + 0.25(0.58) + 0.25(0.67) = 0.7250$$

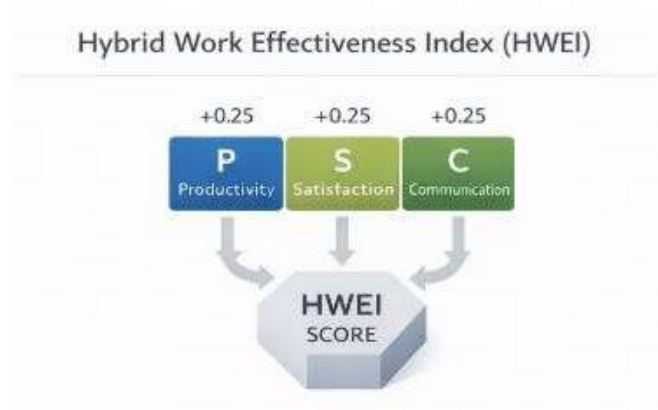


Fig 3. HWEI Index

V. RESULTS AND ANALYSIS

A. Aggregate HWEI Scores by Work Modality

Table 4 presents the mean HWEI scores aggregated across all 500 employee records for each work modality. The results are unambiguous in their directional conclusion: the hybrid model yields the highest mean effectiveness score across the composite index.

Work Model	Mean HWEI	Rank	vs. Office (Δ)
Hybrid (3+2)	0.74	1st	+0.11
Fully Remote	0.69	2nd	+0.06
Fully In-Office	0.63	3rd	—

Table 4. Mean HWEI Scores by Work Modality

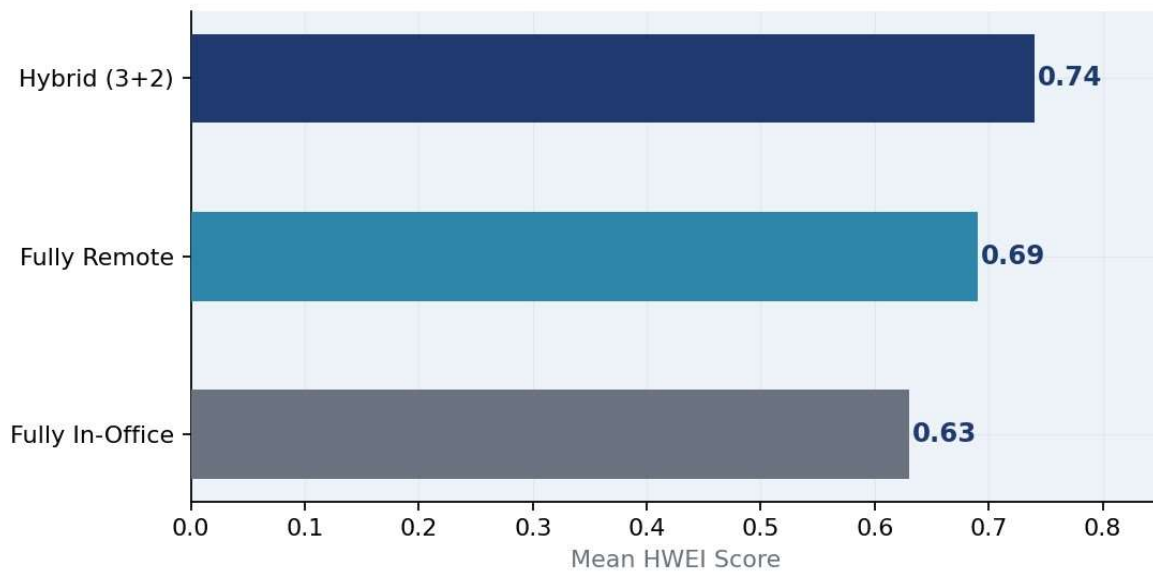
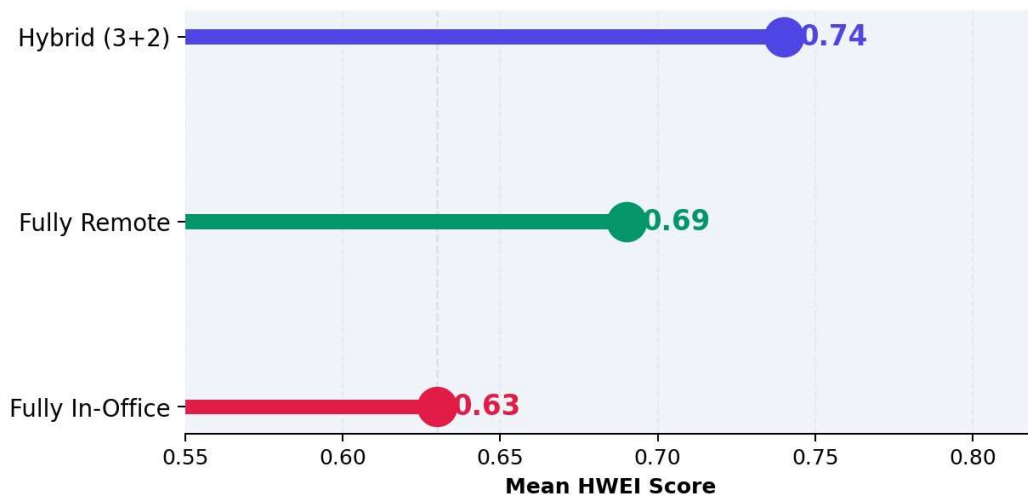


Figure 4. Mean HWEI Scores by Work Modality

Figure 4: Mean HWEI Scores by Work Modality



B. Dimensional Analysis

Table 5 presents mean dimensional scores for each work modality before normalization. The pattern of inter-modality differences varies substantially across dimensions, underscoring the importance of composite measurement.

Work Model	Productivity	Satisfaction	Communication	Cost Efficiency
Hybrid (3+2)	76.8	82.1	69.4	0.67
Fully Remote	71.5	75.2	51.8	1.00
Fully In-Office	64.3	53.8	82.0	0.00

Table 5. Mean Dimensional Scores by Work Modality

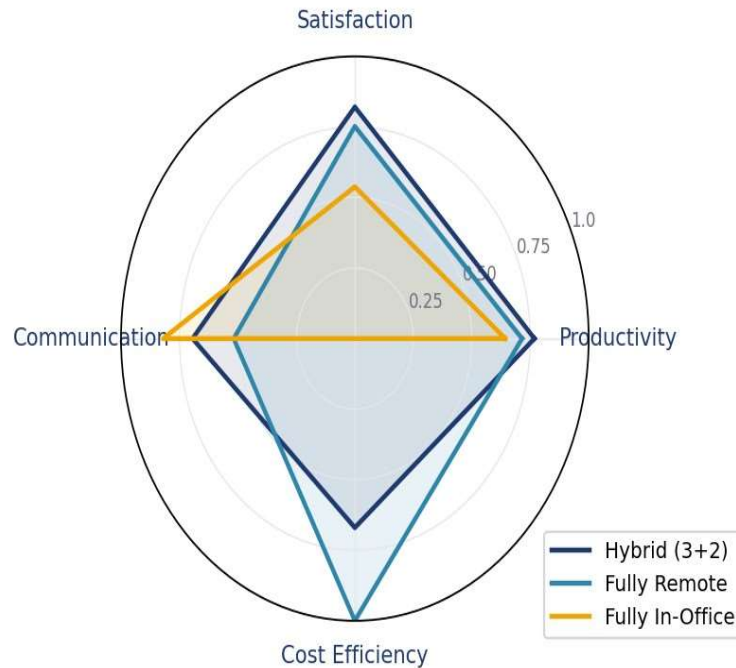
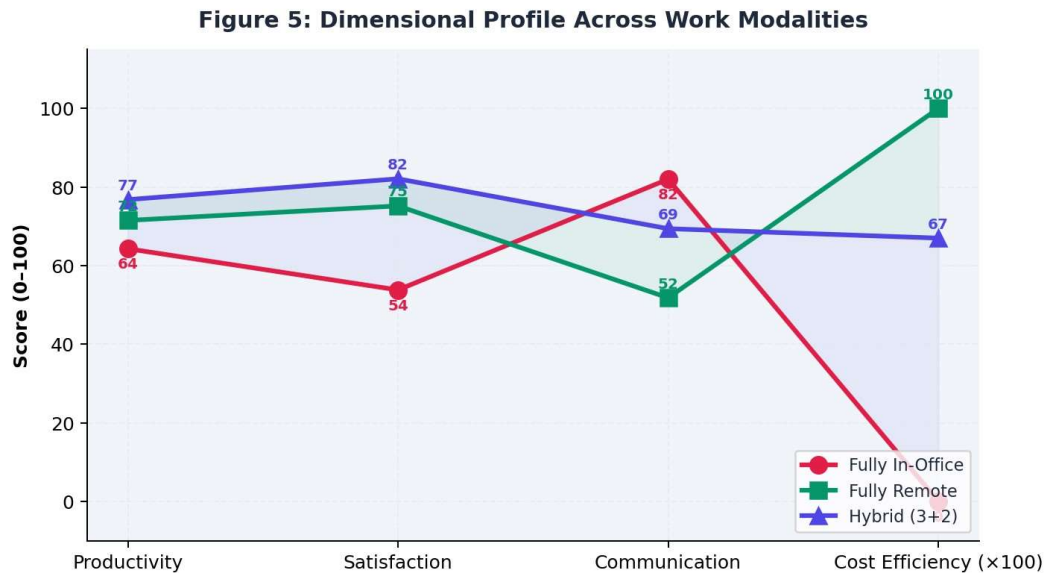


Figure 5. Dimensional Profile by Work Modality (Radar Chart)



C. Communication as the Critical Challenge

One of the most important findings of the study is that communication quality still remains weaker in hybrid and remote work setups compared to fully office-based work. Even the hybrid model, where employees work from the office three days a week, scored around 12.6 points lower than the fully office-based model in communication quality. This shows that simply bringing employees together for a few office days is not enough to completely recreate the natural and informal communication that happens in a full-time office environment.

This finding is important for companies designing hybrid work policies. Organizations should not just copy normal office routines into hybrid setups. Instead, they need to invest properly in better

asynchronous communication systems, strong documentation practices, and planned relationship-building activities during office days.

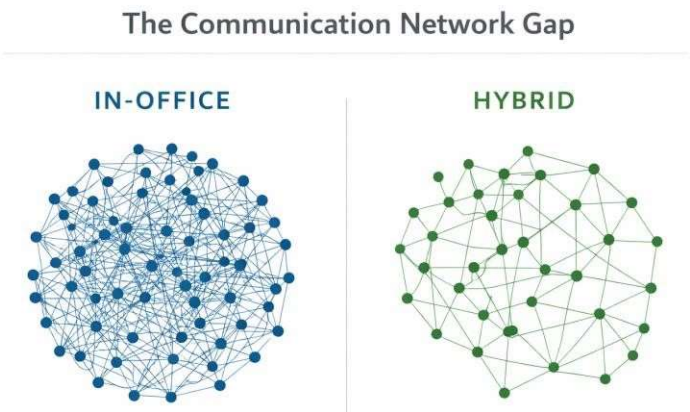
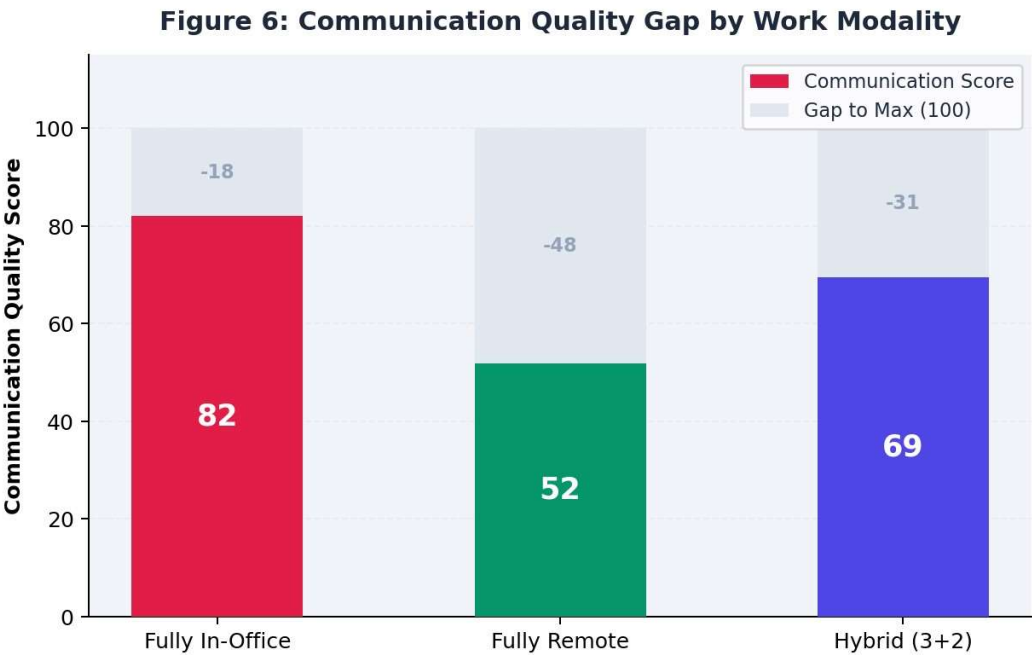


Fig.6 The Communication Network gap



VI. DISCUSSION

A. Interpretation of HWEI Rankings

The HWEI framework clearly shows an important trade-off that is often missed when studies focus on only one factor at a time. The work model that performs best in one area is not always the best overall model. Office-based work performs best for communication, while remote work performs best for

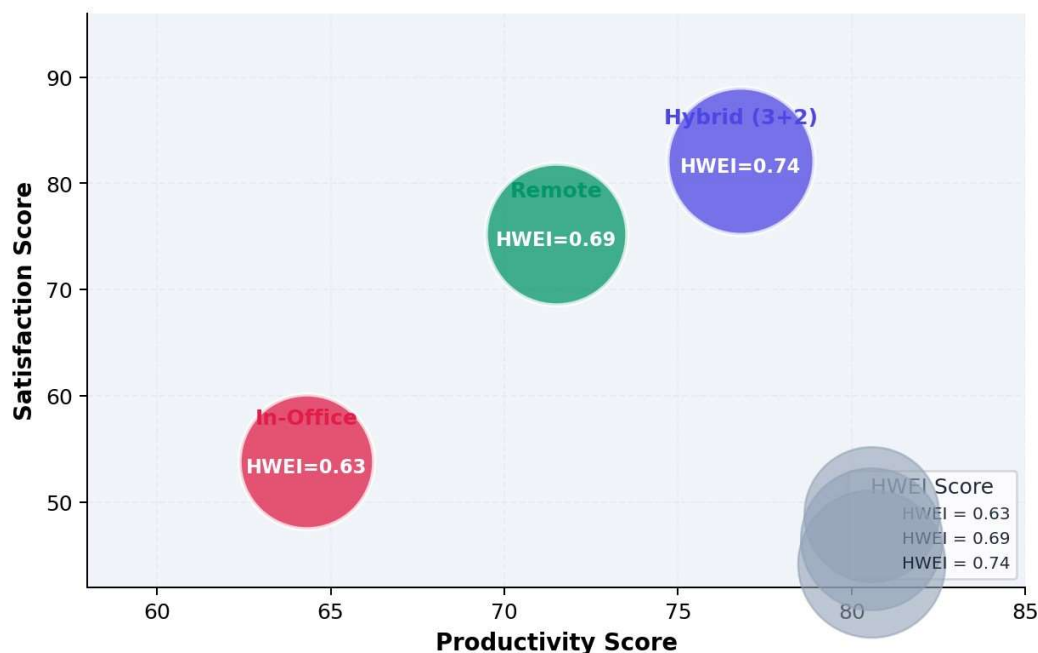
reducing costs. However, neither of these becomes the strongest overall option when all important factors are considered together. The hybrid model performs well across all four dimensions at the same time, even if it is not ranked first in every single category.

This finding has an important strategic meaning for organizations. Companies that judge work models using only one factor — especially productivity or cost — may underestimate the real value of hybrid work. By focusing too narrowly, they can miss how hybrid work also improves employee satisfaction and communication, which strongly affect employee retention and long-term business performance.



Fig 7. Dimension-Wise Comparison

**Figure 7: Productivity vs Satisfaction
(Bubble size = HWEI Score)**



B. The Role of Organizational Design

The HWEI scores shown in this study represent average results, but actual performance can still vary a lot within each work model. Some hybrid work setups may perform worse than very well-managed remote

setups, while some remote setups may perform worse than strong hybrid systems. The current framework does not fully capture these differences, but it highlights an important practical point: simply adopting a hybrid model does not automatically guarantee high effectiveness.

The success of a hybrid work setup depends heavily on how the organization designs and manages it. Factors such as scheduling rules, meeting culture, performance management methods, and investment in communication tools play a major role in deciding whether the hybrid model works successfully.

This matches McKinsey's (2023) finding that company practices matter more than the work model itself. Because of this, the 3+2 model proposed in this study should be seen as a basic structural framework rather than a complete ready-made solution.

C. Sensitivity to Weighting Assumptions

The study gives equal importance to all four factors by using the same weight value ($\alpha_i = 0.25$) for each one. This works well as a starting point, but it may not match the priorities of every organization. For example, a company focused heavily on reducing costs might increase the weight of cost efficiency (O) to 0.40 and lower the weights of the other factors. Similarly, a company focused on hiring and retaining talented employees might give employee satisfaction (S) a higher weight of 0.40.

Even when different weighting combinations were tested during informal sensitivity analysis, the hybrid model still remained the top-performing option in most situations, although the size of its advantage changed. This ability to stay effective even when the weighting system changes makes the framework practically strong and reliable.

D. Limitations

The study has several important limitations that should be recognized. First, the dataset used in the research is synthetic. Although it was designed to closely match patterns found in published studies, it still cannot fully represent the unique differences and real-world variations found in actual company data. Second, the study uses a cross-sectional approach, which means the HWEI only measures results at one point in time instead of tracking long-term changes. Because of this, long-term effects of hybrid work — such as its impact on company culture, career growth, and knowledge sharing — were not measured.

Third, giving equal importance to all four dimensions may not be suitable for every organization because different companies may have different priorities. Fourth, the study does not specifically analyze differences across industries, job roles, or demographic groups, even though existing research shows that these factors can strongly influence hybrid work outcomes.

VII. POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS

A. For Organizational Leaders

- Use the 3+2 hybrid work model as a starting structure, where office days are mainly used for teamwork, relationship-building, and creative collaboration, while remote days are focused on deep and independent work.
- Invest properly in asynchronous communication systems such as clear documentation practices, decision tracking, and organized knowledge management to reduce communication problems caused by remote work.

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- Measure work model success using combined metrics instead of focusing on only one factor. Looking only at productivity can give an incomplete and misleading view of the actual value of hybrid work.
 - Build fair performance management systems that evaluate employees based on their work results and outcomes instead of how often they are physically present in the office. This can help reduce promotion bias against remote employees.
 - Regularly collect employee feedback about how well the work model is functioning through structured feedback systems instead of depending only on employee resignations or turnover rates, which usually show problems too late..

B. For Future Research

- Conduct long-term studies that track HWEI scores over time while considering how organizations gradually improve and adapt to hybrid work.
- Repeat the research using real company data from multiple organizations, industries, and countries to compare results more broadly.
- Include AI-based communication tools in the HWEI framework either as a new fifth factor or as something that affects communication quality.
- Study how hybrid work impacts different groups of employees differently based on factors such as job role, career stage, family situation, and demographic background.

VIII. CONCLUSION

This paper introduced and applied the Hybrid Work Effectiveness Index (HWEI), a combined framework designed to measure how effective different work models are. Using a research-based synthetic dataset of 500 employees, the study found that the hybrid 3+2 model achieved the highest average HWEI score of 0.74, performing better than fully remote work at 0.69 and fully office-based work at 0.63.

The main contribution of this study is not just the final scores, because results can change depending on the organization and situation. The more important contribution is the framework itself. By creating a system that measures productivity, employee satisfaction, communication quality, and cost efficiency together, the study gives organizations a much more complete way to evaluate work models instead of focusing on only one factor.

The study also found that communication quality remains the biggest challenge in both hybrid and remote work setups. Solving this problem requires more than just deciding office and remote days. Companies also need to improve meeting culture, informal communication methods, and knowledge-sharing systems for distributed teams.

In the future, the real question is not simply whether hybrid work is better than other work models. The more important question is which organizational practices make hybrid work successful in different situations. The HWEI framework is presented as a practical tool to help organizations answer that question in a structured and reliable way.

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